

TOP PERFORMERS IN MOST IMPROVED CATEGORY

RANK	STATE	APPEARANCES IN TOP 5* (2018-2022)
1	ASSAM	29
2	BIHAR	28
3	ANDHRA PRADESH	27
3	MADHYA PRADESH	27
5	WEST BENGAL	24
6	JHARKHAND	21

*Across the 12 categories

3 His government has continued the trend of increased budgetary expenditure–from Rs 41,931 crore in 2016-17 to Rs 1.2 crore now. The expenditure has been dovetailed strategically into the social sector and the infrastructure sector in the past few years

4 The CM focused on faster public service delivery by fast-tracking technological intervention in all the services under the Assam Right to Public Services Act, 2012. Such interventions have resulted in people accessing services from the comfort of their homes

5 Several flagship schemes aimed at financial inclusion and social welfare have led to strengthening of rural economy and empowerment of the marginalised. The cash transfer to women under the Orunodoi scheme has helped the state improve IMR and MMR, claims the CM

vember this year, adding more services to its ecosystem. Then, areas of growth were identified in each sector—in the primary sector, agriculture, tea production and bamboo cultivation; in secondary, industries, oil, gas, cement and those which are agro-processing-based and wood-based and in the services sector, tourism. And to facilitate ease of doing business, several policy reforms were initiated in the past five years.

Sarma has repeatedly said that financial inclusion is the first step towards inclusive growth. One of the state's flagship programmes has been the Orunodoi Scheme. Under this, Rs 1,000 cash is transferred every month to the bank accounts of around 2 million beneficiaries—all women. On the criticism that such cash transfer schemes—or freebies—are designed to attract voters, the CM says that these have gone a long way in empowering women, reviving the rural economy, and even reducing the infant and maternal mortality rates. "There is empirical evidence that such support to the poor enhances their spending abilities, which in turn has a cascading effect on the economy. These are not freebies, rather tools of socio-economic empowerment."

To enhance financial inclusion, around 19 million bank accounts have been opened, of which 60 per cent belong to women. The number of bank branches has increased by around 20 per cent in the past three years. Apart from Orunodoi, there are 17 other flagship schemes, which have been designed in a dynamic way to modify them as per changing requirements.

Beyond the macro focus, Sarma is cautious enough not to lose sight of the goal of equitable development, particularly in social sectors keeping in mind the diversity in the state's ethnic composition. For instance, to improve access to education at the secondary level, the government has set up 117 model high schools in tea garden areas, 10 colleges are provincialised in Bodoland Territorial Region. "Development will have no meaning for me if every citizen of the state, irrespective of geography, religion or ethnicity, doesn't feel part of the process," says Sarma. And rightly so. ■